

BANDEEP SINGH

THE GREEN SURVEY

TOTAL GEOGRAPHICAL AREA
3,287,469 square kilometres

TOTAL FOREST COVER

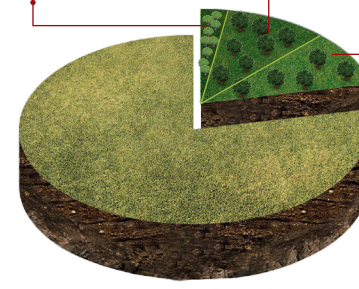
2021	2019
713,789 sq. km	712,249 sq km
21.71%	21.67%

VERY DENSE FOREST (VDF)*

2021	2019
99,779 sq km	99,278 sq km
3.04%	3.02%

MODERATELY DENSE FOREST (MDF)**

2021	2019
306,890 sq. km	308,472 sq. km
9.33%	9.39%



OPEN FOREST (OF)#

2021	2019
307,120 sq. km	304,499 sq. km
9.34%	9.26%

● Area (square kilometres)
● Percentage of geographical area

*VDF: Tree canopy of 70 per cent and above
**MDF: Tree canopy of 40-70 per cent
#OF: Tree canopy cover of 10-40 per cent

Source: India State of Forest Report 2019 & 2021

Graphic by ASIT ROY

industrialisation may lead to an increase in GDP and plantations to a hike in forest cover, their environmental cost should be factored in," she says.

The decline in MDF can be attributed partly due to populations living alongside, converting the areas to open forests, and partly to loss to development projects. Data from the ministry of environment, forests and climate change reveals that nearly 830 sq. km of forest land was diverted to non-forestry use between 2016 and 2021.

As many as 17 states and Union territories have more than a third of their geographical area under forest cover. The northeastern states have the highest forest cover as a percentage of their total area. While Andhra Pradesh, Telangana and Odisha recorded an increase in forest cover, 11 other states, including Arunachal Pradesh, Assam, Manipur, Mizoram, Nagaland, Meghalaya, Delhi, Punjab, Sikkim, Tripura and West Bengal, reported a decline in forest cover over the previous assessment.

Considering the modest gains, will India be able to honour its commitment to expand forest cover to a third of its area, as enshrined in the National Forest Policy, 1988? Yes, but again with the expedient of amending the Forest Conservation Act, 1980, to incentivise plantations on private lands and thereby attain policy objectives.

As Kanchi Kohli, senior researcher at the Centre for Policy Research, New Delhi, points out in a critique of the 2021 report, "The ISFR exercise is directed at counting forest cover and not assessing the quality of forests. It is not a surprise that the methodology is routinely adapted to show that we are nearing the national forest policy targets or India's climate adaptation targets. This is the case with ISFR 2021 too."

Another clever inclusion in the latest ISFR 2021 is the forest cover in tiger reserves and corridors, and lion conservation areas. India has 52 tiger reserves, occupying a total area of 74,710 sq. km, of which 74.51 per cent (55,666 sq. km) is forest cover. Of these, 20 have recorded a gain and 32 contributed to a net decline of 22.62 sq. km of forest cover in the past decade. The decline in forest cover in these tiger reserves is surprising, since they enjoy the highest degree of protection under law and have the greatest number of resources deputed for their protection.

While the data helps assess the health of tiger reserves, how accurately it depicts net increase in forest cover is debatable. Ecological dishonesty is unlikely to do the cause any good. ■



BHUPENDRA YADAV
Union environment minister

"THE MODI GOVT.'S FOCUS IS TO CONSERVE FORESTS NOT JUST QUANTITATIVELY BUT ALSO QUALITATIVELY"